



ENERGY SECURITY

Modern economies need secure access to cheap energy. Relying on imported oil leaves economies vulnerable to foreign wars and social unrest. They must also compete for energy supplies with expanding economies such as China. In the short-term, they may have to deal with unpleasant regimes, or even go to war to protect supply lines. However, in the long term, some economies look to build security by finding new energy sources at home, such as nuclear power, or developing renewable sources.



RENEWABLE AND SUSTAINABLE

“Renewable” sources of energy are those that never run out or are continually renewed. But the link between burning fossil fuels and global warming creates an urgent need to develop energy sources that are also “sustainable,” meaning they can be used long term with no damaging effects. Key renewable and sustainable sources are water, wind, and solar power.



REDUCING CONSUMPTION

Burning fossil fuels damages our planet, so many experts argue that we must also reduce consumption. At the international climate change conference in Paris in 2015, the countries of the world committed to keep global temperature rises “well below 3.5°F (2°C),” largely by cutting consumption of fossil fuels. Many developed countries have pledged to cut carbon emissions by the energy sector in half.

Energy use has tripled over the last 50 years—most of the increase is in fossil fuels.